

Board 1

South Deals
None Vul

♠ A 6 2
♥ K J 8 5 2
♦ 9 8
♣ 10 7 3

♠ Q 10 9 8 4
♥ A 4
♦ Q 7 2
♣ 8 6 5



♠ 7 5 3
♥ Q 6
♦ J 10 6 4
♣ K J 9 2

♠ K J
♥ 10 9 7 3
♦ A K 5 3
♣ A Q 4

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2♥	Pass	2♠
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South

It is pretty clear that the 4 additional winners you need will be ♠s. The danger is that when you force out the ♠A the defenders might be able to cash 4 ♥s right away. So the immediate decision is whether you take the ♥A on the first trick or wait until the second.

If West has only 4 ♥s it will make no difference what you do because they will only win 3 ♥ tricks and you will make your contract. So assume that West has a 5-card suit, which means that East has 2 ♥s. West's suit is definitely **NOT** ♥ K Q J 5 2; he would have started with the ♥K, not the ♥5. So you can be sure that East holds either ♥ K x, ♥ Q x or ♥ J x. So what?

So you should play the ♥A immediately. If East puts on his small ♥ then his lone honor will block the suit the next time it is played. But if he unblocks the honor under dummy's ♥A then your ♥ 10 9 7 will be promoted into a second stopper.

If you play low on the first trick East will win the ♥Q and return the ♥6 to dummy's ♥A. When West gains the lead with his ♠A he will cash 3 more ♥ tricks. Down 1.

Play the ♥A on the first trick and East is hog-tied. If he plays low the suit blocks, if he sacrifices his ♥Q then your ♥ 10 9 7 prevents West from running the suit.

Partner's 2♥ is a transfer, so you bid 2♠. Partner now bids 2NT.

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Partner is only inviting, so he must have either 9 or 10 points. And since he chose 2NT as the invitation he must have only 5 ♠s. You will accept the invitation since you have a maximum 1NT opener, and you choose 3NT since you know there is no 8-card ♠ fit.

South plays 3NT. When West leads the ♥5 you have an immediate decision to make.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 5
 ♥ K Q J 6 5 2
 ♦ A 6 4
 ♣ 9 4 3

♠ K 9 8 6

♥ A 10 4

♦ 10 7 5 2

♣ A 2



♠ Q J 4 2

♥ 8 3

♦ 9 8 3

♣ 10 8 6 5

♠ A 10 7 3

♥ 9 7

♦ K Q J

♣ K Q J 7

West	North	East	South
			1NT
2♥	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♥	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by South

cue-bid following the lebensohl 2NT also promises a stopper in the enemy suit. In any case, partner replies 3♠. Next?

You bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by North.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♥K. Do you take the first trick or not?

Loser List: ♠ = 1/2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 3/4

You should not hold up on the ♥ for two reasons. First, East might have a singleton. Second, you might not have a ♥ loser at all (if you can discard both of dummy's ♥ losers on your ♣s).

So win the ♥A and start on trumps by playing ♠A, then ♠K. Uh Oh. East discards a ♥ on the second ♠ so you have two ♠ losers.

Now you will have to be lucky. Leave the two master trumps undrawn and start running the ♣s. Fortunately East has 4 ♣s and you are able to discard both of dummy's ♥ losers. Play a ♦ next and your luck continues when it is West who takes the trick. Since East can't get in to pull your trumps, you cannot be defeated. You play your ♦ winners and ruff a ♥ in dummy. East will get his two trumps at the end.

Imagine what would have happened if you had played a third trump.

East would have taken the two trump tricks, then West would have taken 5 ♥ tricks and the ♦A.

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Now you cue-bid 3♥. An immediate cue-bid would have been Stayman, (for the other Major), but the cue-bid following the lebensohl 2NT also promises a stopper in the enemy suit. In any case, partner replies 3♠. Next?

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Board 5

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K Q 10 4 2

♥ K 8 2

♦ 4

♣ 10 8 5 3

♠ A J 7

♥ 7 6 4

♦ K Q 9 7

♣ A Q 2



♠ 8 6 5 3

♥ J 10 9 3

♦ 6 2

♣ 9 7 4

♠ 9

♥ A Q 5

♦ A J 10 8 5 3

♣ K J 6

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	3♦
Pass	4♦	Pass	4♥
Pass	4♠	Pass	6♦
All Pass			

6♦ by South
partner is to jump in a suit, so you bid 3♦.

With 17 points and a 6-card suit you are definitely thinking about slam. The way to suggest slam to partner is to jump in a suit, so you bid 3♦.

Partner says 4♦, bypassing 3NT and agreeing to your suit;

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Partner says 4♦, bypassing 3NT and agreeing to your suit;

Typically you start showing controls, up the line. So you bid 4♥, showing the ♥A. Partner then bids 4♠.

With 17 points and a 6-card suit you are definitely thinking about slam. The way to suggest slam to

Partner says 4♦, bypassing 3NT and agreeing to your suit;

Typically you start showing controls, up the line. So you bid 4♥, showing the ♥A. Partner then bids 4♠.

When partner shows first round ♠ control you know you don't have two quick losers, so you bid 6♦.

South plays 6♦. West leads the ♠K. You win West's opening lead with dummy's ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

You only have one too many losers, and you have a very obvious finesse for the ♥K. But first you pull trumps in two rounds. Do you take the ♥ finesse now?

No you don't. In fact you won't need to take it at all, not with that very valuable ♠J in dummy.

Play a ♣ to dummy's ♣Q, then ruff the ♠7 in your hand. Next play ♣K, then another ♣ to dummy's ♣A. Play the ♠J from dummy and discard your ♥5. West will win this trick, (from the opening lead you knew he had the ♠Q), but he will be end-played. A ♠ or a ♣ will give you a ruff/sluff, but a ♥ will give you a free finesse into your ♥A Q.

There is no doubt that a finesse will save a contract for you sometimes.

Sometimes being about 50% of the time on average.

So whenever you see your contract depending on a finesse, just look again and see if perhaps an elimination play is available.